The man tasked with ensuring the revitalisation of the DBSA in the region was Moe Shaik, who trained as an optometrist but became the leading spy in the Zuma government prior to numerous internal crises in the National Intelligence Agency. One problem was his revelation of important and highly embarrassing political secrets to US embassy officials, which in turn were published by WikiLeaks. Shaik's forced resignation from the security services in 2012 was followed by a brief Harvard executive course, after which he was controversially appointed the DBSA's main liaison to the region.

The overall impression left by the DBSA is that it is blatantly ecologically destructive, privatisation-oriented, hostile to social concerns, and incompetent. These problems should logically disqualify the DBSA from being a core contributor to the BRICS New Development Bank, as is often proposed by leading South African officials, who until mid-2014 even anticipated a potential hosting role.

Conclusion

In short, it is obvious that corporations from the BRICS countries have intensified extractivism in Mozambique, Zimbabwe and other sites in Africa, at a time when the continent's wealth is being rapidly evacuated, in large part due to corporate malpractices. These include tax evasion, transfer mispricing and outright theft of minerals. BRICS elites – both country leaders and corporations – are not allies of ordinary Africans, but rather are pursuing their own agendas. Without a clear strategy of maximising gains and minimising losses, Africa is likely to come out of the BRICS engagement worse off, having lost its valuable assets, seeing the environment destroyed, witnessing debilitating political corrosion, and with a much poorer population.